Menstrual cups: HMTc Standard

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CORRESPONDENCE

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KEYWORDS

heavy metals, food safety, dietary exposure

PUBLICATION HISTORY

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Abstract

The Heavy Metal Tested & Certified heavy-metal-safety standard for menstrual cups (silicone, latex, and other polymers) (Feminine Care), evaluated on the total heavy-metal content of the finished article as placed on market (mucosal basis, prolonged internal contact). No government sets a per-metal numeric content limit for this menstrual product, so every analyte is held to a disclosed read-across by analogy, the strictest health-based limit a government sets for an article in comparable prolonged mucosal contact, with inorganic arsenic and methylmercury bounded by their parent totals.

1 | How every number on this standard is set

HMTc Method v2.0 (government-limit default). Device forms carry no per-metal numeric heavy-metal content limit, so every panel cell is a disclosed read-across by analogy to the strictest health-based limit a government sets for an article in comparable prolonged mucosal contact; no occurrence percentile is computed and no number is originated by HMTc. Cosmetic forms read across the strictest sovereign mucosal-contact cosmetic contaminant limit. Two basis families (device content, cosmetic content) are never conflated, and neither is a leachate/migration number. Provenance vocabulary: {regulatory-alignment, read-across, not-material, control, ratchet}.

2 | Master limit table

All values in ppb (µg/kg), as sold basis. A brand meeting every value qualifies for the mark.

ANALYTE	HMTC LIMIT	BASIS
Lead (Pb)	500	human-grade read-across (DE)
Cadmium (Cd)	100	human-grade read-across (DE)
Total arsenic (tAs)	500	human-grade read-across (DE)
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	≤ tAs	bounded by tAs (reflex speciation)
Mercury, total (tHg)	100	human-grade read-across (DE)
Methylmercury (MeHg)	≤ tHg	bounded by tHg (reflex speciation)
Nickel (Ni)	10,000	human-grade read-across (South Korea)
Tin (Sn)	3,750,000	human-grade read-across (European Union)
Aluminium (Al)	560,000	human-grade read-across (European Union)
Total chromium (Cr)	50	human-grade read-across (AU)
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	5	human-grade read-across (European Union)

3 | Derivation — where each number comes from

Every cell traces to one named sovereign maximum level (the strictest for the nearest analog), or to an explicit control, not-material, or species-bounded determination. No occurrence statistic selects a certification value.

ANALYTE	HMTC	SOVEREIGN ANALOG / DETERMINATION
Lead (Pb)	500	DE — human-food analog
Cadmium (Cd)	100	DE — human-food analog
Total arsenic (tAs)	500	DE — human-food analog
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	≤ tAs	iAs carries no product-specific sovereign cell; it is a component of and bounded by its parent total tAs (iAs <= tAs), an enforceable ceiling via reflex speciation rather than an empty cell.
Mercury, total (tHg)	100	DE — human-food analog

Methylmercury (MeHg)	≤ tHg	MeHg carries no product-specific sovereign cell; it is a component of and bounded by its parent total tHg (MeHg <= tHg), an enforceable ceiling via reflex speciation rather than an empty cell.
Nickel (Ni)	10,000	South Korea — human-food analog
Tin (Sn)	3,750,000	European Union — human-food analog
Aluminium (Al)	560,000	European Union — human-food analog
Total chromium (Cr)	50	AU — human-food analog
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	5	European Union — human-food analog

4 | Cite this standard

Pendergrass, K. (2026). *Menstrual cups: HMTc standard* (Standard No. 10.83138/hmtc.std.15.menstrual-cups). Institute of Contaminant Standards. https://doi.org/10.83138/hmtc.std.15.menstrual-cups

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References

[1] AU — human-food maximum levels
Binds Cr. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[2] DE — human-food maximum levels
Binds Pb, Cd, tAs, tHg. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[3] European Union — human-food maximum levels
Binds Sn, Al, Cr-VI. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[4] South Korea — human-food maximum levels
Binds Ni. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

STATUS AND LICENCE

A normative certification standard, editorially reviewed and version-controlled in-house; every value traces to a named sovereign maximum level, disclosed in the derivation. © 2026 Institute of Contaminant Standards / Heavy Metal Certified. All rights reserved.

COMPETING INTERESTS

This briefing is published by the Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc) program, operated by the Institute of Contaminant Standards. Its statements about government regulations, toxicology, and occurrence are sourced to the cited primary and expert-body records and to the independently maintained Heavy Metal Index; the program's

own certification thresholds are not used as evidence for any factual claim made here.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The works this reference draws on are listed in full in the references above and on the briefing page at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/menstrual-cups. Primary legal instruments and expert-body assessments are named with their public identifiers; the underlying occurrence and toxicology corpus is maintained on the Heavy Metal Index.

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